CHAPTER 2. WITH WHAT KINDS OF PEOPLE THE ROMANS HAD TO FIGHT, AND HOW STUBBORNLY THOSE PEOPLE DEFENDED THEIR FREEDOM [*WITH DISCUSSION OF THE EFFECTS OF CHRISTIANITY*]

[*The free peoples of Italy*]

Nothing made it harder for the Romans to conquer the people around them and part of the lands at a distance than the love that in those times many peoples had for their freedom, which they defended so stubbornly that never except by the utmost vigor could they be subjugated. We learn from many instances in what perils they put themselves in order to maintain or regain that freedom, and what revenge they wreaked on those who took it from them. We also learn from the reading of histories what injuries peoples and cities receive from servitude. In our times there is but a single land that can be said to have in it free cities,[1] yet in ancient times there were in all lands many peoples completely free. In those times of which we are at present speaking in Italy, from the mountains that divide what is now Tuscany from Lombardy all the way to the point of Italy, the peoples were all free, such as the Tuscans, the Romans, the Samnites, and many others that lived in that section of Italy. Nor do we read that there was ever any king there except those who ruled in Rome, and Porsenna, King of Tuscany. How his family was wiped out, history does not tell, but it is very plain that in the times when the Romans went to besiege Veii, Tuscany was free, and it so much enjoyed its liberty and so much hated the name of prince that when the Veientians for their protection had established a king in Veii and were asking aid from the Tuscans against the Romans, the Tuscans, after holding many consultations, determined not to give aid to the Veientians so long as they lived under a king, thinking it not good to defend the country of those who had already submitted it to another.[2]

1. *Germany; see Index.*
2. *Livy 5. 1.*

[*Freedom has brought prosperity*]

It is easy to learn why this love for free government springs up in people, for experience shows that cities never have increased in dominion or in riches except while they have been at liberty. Truly it is a marvelous thing to consider to what greatness Athens came in the space of a hundred years after she freed herself from the tyranny of Pisistratus. But above all, it is very marvelous to observe what greatness Rome came to after she freed herself from her kings. The reason is easy to understand, because not individual good but common good is what makes cities great. Yet without doubt this common good is thought important only in republics, because everything that advances it they act upon, and however much harm results to this or that private citizen, those benefited by the said common good are so many that they are able to press it on against the inclination of those few who are injured by its pursuit.

[*Under tyranny countries stagnate*]

The opposite happens when there is a prince; then what benefits him usually injures the city, and what benefits the city injures him. For that reason, as soon as a tyranny is established over a free community, the smallest evil that results for those cities is that they no longer go forward and no longer increase in power or in riches; but in most instances, in fact always, they go backward. If chance brings about the rise of a vigorous tyrant, who through courage and through force of arms increases his dominion, no advantage comes from it to that state, but only to himself, because he cannot honor any of those citizens he tyrannizes over who are strong and good, unless he is willing to fear them. Nor can he, moreover, subordinate or make tributary to that city where he is tyrant the cities he conquers, because making his city powerful does not benefit him, but it does benefit him to keep his state disunited and to have each city and each province acknowledge him. Hence he alone profits from his conquests—not his country. Let any man who wishes to support this opinion with countless other arguments read the tractate Xenophon composed *On Tyranny*.

[*The ancients loved freedom*]

We need not wonder, then, that the ancient peoples with such great hatred strove to overthrow tyrants and that they loved free

government and highly esteemed the name of liberty. This was shown when Hieronymus, grandson of Hiero of Syracuse, was killed in Syracuse, for when the news of his death came to his army, which was not very far from Syracuse, at first they began to riot and to take arms against his murderers, but when they heard that in Syracuse there was a proclamation of freedom, being attracted by that name, they entirely quieted down, laid aside their anger against the tyrannicides, and considered how in that city they could organize a free government.[3]

[*Revenge on the enemies of freedom*]

We also need not wonder that the people take awful revenge on those who deprive them of their liberty. Of this there have been many instances, of which I am going to mention but one. It happened in Corcyra, a city in Greece, in the times of the Peloponnesian War. Greece was then divided into two parties, of which one followed the Athenians, the other the Spartans; consequently in many divided cities one party sought the friendship of Sparta, the other that of Athens. When it happened that in Corcyra the nobles won the mastery and took away the people's freedom, the popular party with Athenian aid regained its strength and, laying hands on all the nobility, shut them up in a prison that would hold them all. From this they took them out eight or ten at a time, under the pretext of sending them into exile in different places, and with many spectacular cruelties put them to death. Those who remained, being informed of this, determined to make every effort to escape that ignominious death; so, arming themselves as best they could, they fought against those who tried to enter, and defended the prison gates. Thereupon the people, running there as soon as they heard the noise, unroofed the upper part of that place and with the ruins smothered them. In that country there ensued many other similar events both horrible and striking; hence it clearly is true that freedom taken from you is avenged with greater fury than freedom which someone plans to take from you.

[*Modern religion does not favor freedom*]

Pondering, then, why it can be that in those ancient times people were greater lovers of freedom than in these, I conclude it came from

3. *Livy 24. 21.*

the same cause that makes men now less hardy. That I believe is the difference between our religion and the ancient. Ours, because it shows us the truth and the true way, makes us esteem less the honor of the world; whereas the pagans, greatly esteeming such honor and believing it their greatest good, were fiercer in their actions. This we infer from many of their institutions, beginning with the magnificence of their sacrifices, compared with the mildness of ours. There is in ours some pomp, more delicate than magnificent, but no action either fierce or vigorous. In theirs neither pomp nor magnificence was lacking in the ceremonies, and in addition there was the deed of sacrifice, full of blood and ferocity in the slaughter of a multitude of animals; this terrible sight made the men resemble it. Ancient religion, besides this, attributed blessedness only to men abounding in worldly glory, such as generals of armies and princes of states. Our religion has glorified humble and contemplative men rather than active ones. It has, then, set up as the greatest good humility, abjectness and contempt for human things; the other put it in grandeur of mind, in strength of body, and in all the other things apt to make men exceedingly vigorous. Though our religion asks that you have fortitude within you, it prefers that you be adapted to suffering rather than to doing something vigorous.

[*Christianity has been interpreted according to sloth*]

This way of living, then, has made the world weak and turned it over as prey to wicked men, who can in security control it, since the generality of men, in order to go to Heaven, think more about enduring their injuries than about avenging them. Though it may appear that the world has grown effeminate, and Heaven has laid aside her arms, this without doubt comes chiefly from the worthlessness of men, who have interpreted our religion according to sloth and not according to vigor. For if they would consider that it allows us the betterment and the defense of our country, they would see that it intends that we love and honor her and prepare ourselves to be such that we can defend her.

[*Modern peoples show little love for freedom*]

By reason of this education, then, and such false interpretations, there are in the world fewer republics than in ancient times, and, as a result, the people do not have such great love for freedom as then.

Still I believe that the cause of this is rather that the Roman Empire with her arms and her greatness wiped out all the republics and all the self-governing communities. And though later that Empire was liquidated, the cities have not yet united themselves or reorganized themselves for government according to law, except in a very few places in that Empire.

[*Roman efficiency*]

However that may be, the Romans in every smallest part of the world did find a league of republics well armed and very stubborn in the defense of their freedom. This shows that the Roman people without unusual and immense ability could never have overcome them. To give an instance of some weight, I am sure that of the Samnites is enough. It seems a wonderful thing—and Titus Livius admits it—that they were so powerful and their armies so strong that as late as the consulate of Papirius Cursor, son of the first Papirius, they could resist the Romans (which was a space of forty-six years) after the many defeats and destructions of cities and the many slaughters suffered in their country, especially when one sees that that country, where there were so many cities and so many men, is now almost uninhabited.[4] Yet then there was such good organization and such force there that it would have been unconquerable, if it had not been attacked with Roman efficiency.

[*Why free countries prosper*]

It is easy to determine whence that organization emerged and whence this confusion is derived; it all comes from living in freedom then and living in slavery now. All cities and provinces that live in freedom anywhere in the world, as I said above, make very great gains. They do so because their populations are larger, since marriages are freer and more attractive to men, and each man gladly begets those children he thinks he can bring up, without fear that his patrimony will be taken from him; he knows not merely that they are born free and not slaves but that by means of their abilities they can become prominent men. Riches multiply in a free country to a greater extent, both those that come from agriculture and those that come from industry, for each man gladly increases such things and seeks to gain such goods as he believes, when gained, he can enjoy.

4. *Livy 10. 31.*

Thence it comes that men in emulation give thought to private and public advantages; and both kinds keep marvelously increasing.

[*The worst slavery is that under a republic*]

The opposite of all these things happens in those countries that live as slaves; and the more they fall away from their wonted good, the harder their slavery is. Of all hard slaveries, the hardest is that subjecting you to a republic: first, because it is more lasting and there is less hope of escape from it; second, because the purpose of a republic is to enfeeble and weaken, in order to increase its own body, all other bodies. This is not done by a prince who subjugates you, if that prince is not some barbarian prince, a destroyer of cities and a waster of all the civilization of men, as are the Oriental princes. But if he has in himself human and ordinary qualities, he usually loves equally the cities subject to him and leaves them all their industries and almost all their old institutions. Hence, if they do not prosper like free men, they also do not go to ruin like slaves. I refer to the slavery of cities subject to a foreigner, because of those subject to one of their own citizens I have spoken above.[5]

He who considers, then, all that has been said, will not be astonished at the power of the Samnites when they were free and at their weakness later when they were slaves. Titus Livius gives us assurance of it in several places and especially in the war with Hannibal,[6] where he shows that when the Samnites were oppressed by a legion of men that was in Nola, they sent ambassadors to Hannibal begging him to rescue them; and in their speech they said that they had for a hundred years fought the Romans with their own soldiers and their own generals, and many times had resisted two consular armies and two consuls, and that then they had come to such a low condition that they were scarcely able to defend themselves from one little Roman legion in Nola.

5. DISCOURSES *1. 40. Cf.* THE PRINCE *9.*
6. *Livy 23. 42.*